IN WASHINGTON, THE OCTOBER 24 MEETING OF EXCOM started exactly at the minute and hour of the official implementation of the blockade. It was 10:00 a.m. Eastern Standard Time on the US East Coast and 14:00 Greenwich Mean Time. The meeting began, as usual, with the report of the CIA director, John McCone, who informed his colleagues that there were twenty-two Soviet ships en route to Cuba. Seven of them had received urgent messages at 1:00 a.m. Moscow time on October 23. All twenty-two received additional messages at 2:30 a.m. EST on October 24. McCone did not know the content of the coded messages, but control over the ships had passed from the headquarters of the Black Sea cargo fleet in Odesa to the headquarters of the Soviet merchant fleet in Moscow.

ExCom was ready to discuss the interception of the ships that did not change their course. Late the previous night John Kennedy had decided after a conversation with his old friend, the ambassador of the United Kingdom, David Ormsby-Gore, that the quarantine line should be established 500 nautical miles off the shores of Cuba. He contacted McNamara immediately, and now they were all working from the same script: the quarantine zone would begin 500 miles away from the island. Dean Rusk's suggestion of the previous day to begin by intercepting a Soviet ship not carrying weapons did not get much support: the administration might be embarrassed if its navy were found stopping ships with baby food. They were looking for ships with weapons on board.

McNamara singled out the *Gagarin* and another Soviet dry cargo ship, the *Kimovsk*, as primary targets. They had discussed the *Kimovsk* the previous day, when it was approximately 1,800 miles from Cuba, and decided to wait an extra day to see where it was heading. They did not know where the *Kimovsk* and the *Gagarin* were at that point but assumed that the vessels were approaching the quarantine line. It was also assumed that they were being escorted by Soviet submarines, making them prime suspects of carrying missiles. McNamara reported that the *Gagarin* had declared its cargo as technical equipment and its port of destination as Conakry—in his opinion, "a typical declaration of an offensive weapons-carrying ship from the Soviet Union." He continued: "We have checked back the records, and this appears to be a typical way by which they propose to deceive."[14]